

operating a business in an overseas country. After that I was back at the head office in Japan to work as a personal assistant to [then Chairman] Osamu Suzuki. I had a big opportunity to learn many things from him. Then I went to another overseas assignment in Hungary. That was our second-biggest overseas factory. Its production at that time was 285,000 units. So, compared to MSI, it's a very small operation but for us it's a reasonably big size and I became the MD for the first time of a manufacturing company there. I

possible. I want them to enjoy this mobility and bring happiness to their lives. But because of material costs increasing so rapidly, there is a supply issue, and it is severely affecting everything, [and] affecting small cars a lot more. At the same time, people prefer to have personal mobility over public transport or shared mobility. We see that there's a strong demand and we want to keep feeding that demand. That's connected to my goal of giving the joy of mobility to small-car buyers, especially in India.

vehicles [EVs] are a big challenge but there are other alternative options available, especially in India. Biofuels, for example, provide a big opportunity because India is a big agricultural country. In India, we have 300 million cows. So, cow dung is like gold here. Also, agricultural waste is there. If we can utilise these to make bio-fuel, it will be very close to carbon neutral. If we can establish this as a main resource for automotive, we can introduce this and export this technology together with the vehicle to other agricultural coun-

per cent of the population has a car. And 97 per cent [of the population] is a huge market potential. I feel this market will keep growing.

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MSI is constantly losing market share. Is that a big concern?

Personally, maybe I'm lucky. Had I got this leadership opportunity when the company was enjoying 53 per cent market share, it would have been very tough to maintain and make it even better. Now, it's a good time for me to try and make some recovery gradually. Maybe, I cannot jump back to 50 per cent in a short time but I can gradually improve market share. And we have a strong product plan to do that, including many SUVs for the Indian market. Plus, we have more ideas to enhance our CNG portfolio. I'm sure this will help us increase market share gradually to as much as close to 50 per cent.

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While the competition is gearing up on EVs, what will MSI's EV strategy look like?

The Indian market is the single-biggest market for the Suzuki group. It's important strategically for the entire Suzuki group. By 2070, India aims to have net zero [emissions] and the Suzuki group is paying extra attention on how to achieve those

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WE'LL DO EVs, BUT WE'RE ALSO TRYING TO TAKE A TECHNOLOGY-NEUTRAL APPROACH. WE DON'T CARE WHICH TECHNOLOGY WE EMPLOY AS LONG AS IT WORKS TOWARDS A BETTER ENVIRONMENT

learnt being responsible for all the employees, their families and the [other] stakeholders.

Then I came back to the head office from Hungary and became involved in the Indian business. Then again, I thought about my goal in life. During my time in the automotive business, I've always felt the joy of mobility. My vision is to give this joy of mobility to as many people in the country as

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What's the biggest challenge for you in the Indian market?

Personally, it's to catch up with Indians speaking English. They speak so fast (*laughs*). From a business point of view, the automotive business itself is facing a big change. How to survive this big change is really a big challenge for Maruti Suzuki and also for the Suzuki group globally. For us, electric

tries like Africa or South America. This can be scaled up as a model to other countries. My focus is to explore these upcoming technologies suited to the Indian market. The biggest difference between the Indian market and other developed markets is that the other markets are saturated and there's not much opportunity for us to grow because their total market is not growing. In India, only 3